Over the past several years, the Trinamool Congress government in West Bengal has been buffeted by a series of corruption allegations that have tarnished its reputation: from the teachers' recruitment scandal to the cow smuggling scam, from the coal imbroglio to cases of extortion by its leaders. Now, a slew of new charges have come up against the ruling party—that of siphoning off funds and rations from the Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman or PM-Poshan scheme (earlier called the Mid-Day Meal Scheme) for children towards other party and governance needs. Into the mix are dishonest businessmen, a pliant administration and a dubious alliance between private and government schools. The irregularities, if proved, could be a new low for the state government.

SUBIR HALDER



THEIR DAILY BREAD Children line up for a mid-day meal at a school in the West Midnapore district of West Bengal

The matter came to light when the West Bengal chapter of the 'Right to Food' campaign—an independent network of organisations working towards ensuring food security—conducted extensive research based on data provided by the state, unearthing a shortfall in the quantity of mid-day meal rations supplied during the pandemic lockdown between April 2020 and June 2022. The deprivation faced by 11.5 million children (the total number of primary and upper primary schoolgoing children in the state) was quantified at 45,593 tonnes of rice. In terms of proteins—mainly provided through vegetables and lentils—each child was deprived of roughly 7 kilos, says the report. The monetary value of the leakage is pegged to be Rs 1,572 crore, which the children were entitled to as part of the scheme.

While the research findings, which hint at an unconscionable offence, have startled many, the whole issue has a particularly bad odour because the National Family Health Survey (NFHS)-5 (2019-21) reveals that 34 per cent of Bengal's children under the age of five are short for their age or are 'stunted', 20 per cent are too thin or 'wasted', seven per cent are 'severely wasted' and 32 per cent are 'underweight'. Worse, these latest figures are distinctly higher in every category from those in NFHS-4 (2015-16). Rights activist Anuradha Talwar, who spearheaded the campaign, says: "NFHS-5 shows high levels of malnutrition among schoolgoing children in Bengal. Hunger is an inevitable part of the lives of children from deprived backgrounds. The school's hot meal is a small relief. But the drop in this during the pandemic impacted their nutrition and it will show up in NFHS-6."

The BJP has also raised red flags, with leader of the opposition Suvendu Adhikari writing to Union HRD minister Dharmendra Pradhan in January about the "biggest ongoing financial scam involving systematic misappropriation and diversion of PM Poshan funds". In his letter, he has provided documents showing how the BDO of Hingalgunj in North 24 Parganas district allegedly diverted Rs 16.25 lakh from mid-day meal funds on account of refreshments for an administrative visit by Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on November 29 and December 1, 2022. Adhikari's letter alleges that funds were being diverted for administrative purposes for over a decade.

Reacting to the letter, and to consistent reports of poor quality food being served in Bengal, the Centre sent teams comprising Union education ministry officials and nutritionists in early February to various parts of the state for a review. The team is yet to disclose its findings.

BJP'S SUVENDU ADHIKARI HAS WRITTEN TO THE CENTRE ABOUT THE POSHAN 'SCAM'. THE TMC SAYS IT'S ALL 'VENDETTA POLITICS'

TMC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh rubbished all claims and dubbed it as vendetta politics. He said, "The state government is implementing the mid-day meal scheme in the best possible way despite a severe financial crunch, as the Centre has stopped funds.... Instead of accusing us, he (Adhikari) should ask his political bosses to release funds." Minister of women and child development Shashi Panja says, "I hope the research is unbiased. We haven't got any report. If they had been genuinely concerned, they would have visited